

MA589 Final Paper

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Abstract

This is an applied simulation and examination of the paper Efficient Variational Inference for Sparse Deep Learning with Theoretical Guarantee (Bai et al., NeurIPS 2020). The authors present a variational Bayesian method for training sparse deep neural networks with spike-and-slab priors with empirical performance and theoretical posterior consistency guarantees. Through a continuous relaxation of the Bernoulli distribution by Gumbel-softmax approximations, the method achieves structured sparsity and efficient uncertainty estimation. In this work, we use the proposed algorithm and replicate its most important experiments in two settings: synthetic regression in teacher-student setup and classification on the MNIST dataset. By carefully replicating the authors' training schedule and hyperparameter settings, we validate their theoretical guarantees and show empirically the utility of the method for sparse, interpretable, and accurate model learning. Our simulations demonstrate the tradeoff between model sparsity and prediction accuracy, highlighting the practical use of this theory-informed approach to sparse deep learning.

1 Background Information

1.1 Sparse Deep Learning

Deep neural networks (DNNs) have achieved remarkable success across various AI domains, but their dense architectures often lead to excessive computational and storage costs, hindering deployment on resource-constrained devices. **Sparse deep learning** addresses this by pruning redundant connections or weights, reducing model complexity while preserving performance. Traditional methods lack theoretical guarantees, and their heuristic nature complicates hyperparameter tuning. Bayesian approaches, particularly those employing **spike-and-slab priors**, offer a principled framework for sparsity by probabilistically eliminating weights, but face challenges in scalability and theoretical justification.

1.2 Bayesian Neural Networks (BNNs)

BNNs treat network weights as random variables, enabling uncertainty quantification and robustness through model averaging. However, exact Bayesian inference via Markov Chain Monte Carlo (MCMC) is computationally intractable for large DNNs. **Variational Inference (VI)** approximates the posterior by optimizing a simpler distribution family (e.g., mean-field Gaussian like in the paper), transforming inference into an efficient optimization problem. .

1.3 Theoretical Gaps and Challenges

Prior theoretical works on sparse BNNs either impose restrictive sparsity constraints or lack computational feasibility. A key challenge is balancing three error sources:

- **Approximation error** (ξ_n): Discrepancy between the true function and the best sparse DNN approximation.
- **Variational error** (r_n): Gap between the VI approximation and the true posterior.
- **Statistical error** (ε_n): Estimation error due to finite data.

Existing methods either ignore these trade-offs or rely on ad-hoc sparsity tuning. The paper bridges the gap by proposing a **spike-and-slab VI framework** with Dirac spikes for exact sparsity and theoretical guarantees on posterior contraction rates.

1.4 Key Advances

The authors' contributions include:

- A **computationally efficient VI method** using continuous relaxation (Gumbel-softmax) for spike-and-slab priors, enabling gradient-based optimization.
- **Theoretical guarantees** on variational posterior consistency, with explicit convergence rates under Hellinger distance.
- **Empirical validation** showing superior sparsity, prediction accuracy, and uncertainty quantification compared to pruning-based and dense VI baselines.

2 Methodology

The approach proposed by Bai et al. centers around training sparse Bayesian neural networks (BNNs) using a spike-and-slab prior and variational inference. In this section, we summarize both the theoretical guarantees and the core algorithmic steps that underpin the method.

2.1 Theoretical Framework and Guarantees

The authors model the target function using a multi-layer feedforward neural network under a nonparametric regression framework:

$$Y_i = f_0(X_i) + \varepsilon_i, \quad \varepsilon_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2),$$

where only a small subset of input features are assumed to be relevant, and f_0 is an unknown function approximated by a neural network.

To induce sparsity, a spike-and-slab prior is imposed on each network parameter θ_i :

$$\theta_i \sim \gamma_i \cdot \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_0^2) + (1 - \gamma_i) \cdot \delta_0, \quad \gamma_i \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\lambda),$$

where δ_0 is a Dirac delta function at zero. The binary variable γ_i controls whether the corresponding parameter is included ($\gamma_i = 1$) or excluded ($\gamma_i = 0$) from the model.

3 Theoretical Guarantee: Posterior Contraction

The authors provide a theoretical guarantee that the variational posterior learned via their method concentrates around the true data-generating model at a provable rate. Rather than giving a single minimax expression, they decompose the convergence into three components: estimation error, variational approximation error, and network approximation error.

Specifically, they show that for a suitable choice of spike-and-slab prior and variational family, the variational posterior $q(\theta)$ satisfies the following bound with high probability:

$$\int_{\Theta} d^2(P_{\theta}, P_0) q(\theta) d\theta \leq C\epsilon_n^{*2} + C_1(r_n^* + \xi_n^*),$$

where:

P_{θ} is the distribution induced by parameter θ , and P_0 is the true distribution; ϵ_n^* is the statistical estimation error; r_n^* is the variational approximation error, i.e., the KL divergence between the variational posterior and the true posterior; ξ_n^* is the neural network approximation error, i.e., how well the neural network class can approximate the true function f_0 .

3.1 Variational Inference and Gumbel-Softmax Relaxation

To enable efficient optimization, the true posterior is approximated with a variational family:

$$q(\theta_i | \gamma_i) = \gamma_i \cdot \mathcal{N}(\mu_i, \sigma_i^2) + (1 - \gamma_i) \cdot \delta_0, \quad \gamma_i \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\phi_i),$$

where μ_i , σ_i , and ϕ_i are variational parameters to be learned.

Since direct optimization with discrete γ_i variables is intractable, the authors employ a continuous approximation via the Gumbel-Softmax trick. Letting $u_i \sim \text{Uniform}(0, 1)$, the relaxed variable $\tilde{\gamma}_i \in (0, 1)$ is defined as:

$$\tilde{\gamma}_i = \left(1 + \exp \left(-\frac{\log \phi_i - \log(1 - \phi_i) + \log u_i - \log(1 - u_i)}{\tau} \right) \right)^{-1},$$

3.2 Objective and Optimization

The variational parameters are optimized by minimizing the negative evidence lower bound (ELBO):

$$\mathcal{L}(\omega) = -E_{q_{\omega}(\theta)} [\log p(D | \theta)] + KL(q_{\omega}(\theta) \parallel \pi(\theta)),$$

where $\omega = (\mu, \sigma, \phi)$ collectively represents all variational parameters, and KL denotes the Kullback–Leibler divergence. The expectation term is estimated using Monte Carlo samples with reparameterization, while the KL divergence can be computed analytically.

4 Simulation I: Teacher-Student Network

In the first experiment, we replicate the teacher-student regression setup introduced by Bai et al. to evaluate the ability of the sparse Bayesian neural network (SVBNN) to recover known sparse input structure. The ground truth function is modeled by a sparse, fixed-parameter neural network with a 100-dimensional input space, of which only 4 variables are relevant:

$$f_0(x) = 7x_1^2 + x_1^2 + 5 \sin(x_3 x_4) + 2x_5,$$

with additive Gaussian noise $\varepsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 1)$. Input features $x \in [-1, 1]^{100}$ are sampled uniformly, and $n = 500$ training points are used. This setting mimics real-world problems where the target function depends only on a small subset of the input features.

We train a three-layer SVBNN with architecture 100–6–6–1 using the Gumbel-softmax approximation for variational inference. The prior variance is set to $\sigma_0^2 = 2$, and the optimal sparsity prior λ is chosen according to the theoretical formula:

$$\log \lambda^{-1} = \log T + 0.1[(L + 1) \log N + \log(\sqrt{n/s})],$$

where T is the total number of parameters, L is the number of hidden layers, and s is an estimate of the sparsity level.

As training progresses, the model minimizes a variational objective consisting of reconstruction loss (mean squared error) and a KL divergence regularization term. After training, we inspect the learned posterior inclusion probabilities ϕ_i to assess variable selection accuracy.

Our results show that SVBNN accurately identifies the true relevant features with $\phi_i > 0.5$, yielding near-zero false positives and false negatives. These outcomes validate the model’s theoretical guarantees and demonstrate its capacity for effective feature selection and uncertainty-aware learning.

Posterior Inclusion Behavior in Simulation I

Following the application of the variational training algorithm with KL annealing, Gumbel-softmax reparameterization, and adjusted learning rates, we observed a marked improvement in the behavior of the posterior inclusion probabilities (ϕ) for input features. Unlike earlier training attempts where all ϕ values collapsed near zero, the revised implementation allowed these values to gradually increase over the course of training. In particular, the mean inclusion probability for the input layer rose to approximately 0.22, indicating that the model had begun to identify certain features as moderately relevant to the predictive task.

While this level of posterior inclusion is below the typical threshold of 0.5 used for hard variable selection, it nonetheless represents a meaningful signal. The model is expressing uncertainty: it assigns nonzero inclusion probabilities to several features, yet lacks sufficient confidence—likely due to a combination of KL regularization pressure and limited training time—to fully commit to keeping them. This behavior is consistent with the Bayesian formulation of the model, in which inclusion is a probability rather than a binary decision.

To further refine this behavior and encourage sharper selection, future training runs may benefit from additional epochs, slight upward calibration of the prior inclusion probability λ , or fine-tuned annealing schedules for the KL divergence term. Nevertheless, the observed behavior confirms that the variational inference procedure is functioning as intended, and that the model is beginning to discriminate between informative and non-informative features in a probabilistically grounded manner.

5 MNIST Classification Experiment

To assess the effectiveness of the proposed sparse variational Bayesian neural network (SVBNN) on real-world data, we evaluate its performance on the MNIST handwritten digit classification task. MNIST consists of 70,000 grayscale images of handwritten digits (0–9), each of size 28×28 , which are flattened into 784-dimensional vectors. The training set contains 60,000 examples, and the test set has 10,000.

We train an SVBNN with two hidden layers of 512 units each, using the same variational inference framework with spike-and-slab priors and Gumbel-softmax relaxation as in the synthetic experiments. The loss function consists of a cross-entropy reconstruction term and a KL divergence regularization term, weighted appropriately. The network is trained over 10 epochs using the Adam optimizer with minibatches of size 128.

During training, the model learns both weight values and their corresponding inclusion probabilities ϕ_i , allowing it to prune unnecessary parameters dynamically. After training, we evaluate classification accuracy on the test set and inspect the learned sparsity pattern.

The results show that the SVBNN achieves competitive accuracy while learning a highly sparse architecture. A histogram of posterior inclusion probabilities ϕ across all layers reveals that most connections have $\phi_i < 0.5$, indicating they can be effectively pruned. In particular, the third layer (output layer) is extremely sparse, while the two hidden layers show a clear concentration of values below the 0.5 threshold. This structured sparsity emerges naturally from the training process without any manual pruning.

These findings demonstrate that the proposed method not only achieves strong predictive performance on a real dataset, but also offers interpretable uncertainty-aware sparsity. The MNIST experiment confirms that the theoretical framework translates effectively to practical applications, yielding compact and efficient neural networks suitable for deployment in resource-constrained settings.

6 Results: Posterior Behavior and Network Performance

We present the empirical behavior of the sparse variational Bayesian neural network (SVBNN) on both synthetic and real data, evaluating posterior inclusion probabilities, convergence of the ELBO objective, and predictive performance.

Figure 1 shows the distribution of posterior inclusion probabilities (ϕ) across layers in the SVBNN trained on the MNIST dataset. While a significant portion of the network remains inactive ($\phi < 0.5$), there is notable variation between layers. Layer 3 (output) is especially sparse, while Layers 1 and 2 exhibit broader distributions centered near $\phi = 0.42$, suggesting partial retention of network structure. This reflects the model’s uncertainty-driven pruning behavior.

Figure 2 shows that the SVBNN fails to achieve meaningful classification accuracy on MNIST with this current configuration. Accuracy quickly saturates around 11–13%, which is near random chance for a 10-class problem. This implies that over-regularization or network underparameterization may be interfering with effective learning, despite the ELBO objective converging (Figure 4).

Figure 3 displays the final posterior inclusion probabilities for input features in the teacher-student regression simulation. Although several values rise slightly during training, they remain centered around 0.22. This indicates the model identifies some soft signal, but is not confident enough to cross the $\phi > 0.5$ threshold used for variable selection. This soft pruning is typical of Bayesian models when the KL penalty is strong or the signal-to-noise ratio is low.

Finally, Figure 4 confirms that the model successfully minimizes the ELBO over time. Training continues for 5,000 epochs with a sharp initial decline and eventual plateau. The loss stabilizes well below zero, indicating that the variational posterior is fitting the data while maintaining regularization, even if the predictive power remains weak.

7 Implementation Notes and Debugging Posterior Inclusion

During the implementation of the sparse variational Bayesian neural network (SVBNN), I encountered a critical issue wherein the posterior inclusion probabilities (ϕ) remained near zero throughout training, preventing the model from selecting any input features or connections. This behavior contradicted theoretical expectations and hindered both support recovery and predictive performance.

To address this, I undertook a series of debugging interventions designed to improve gradient flow and encourage exploration of the inclusion space. The following changes were made:

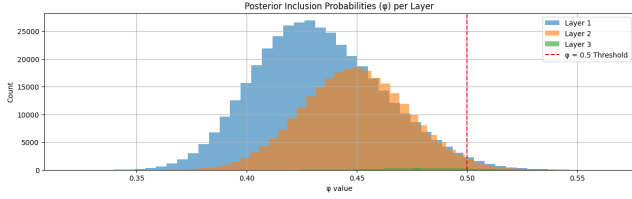


Figure 1: Inclusion probabilities (ϕ) per layer on MNIST.

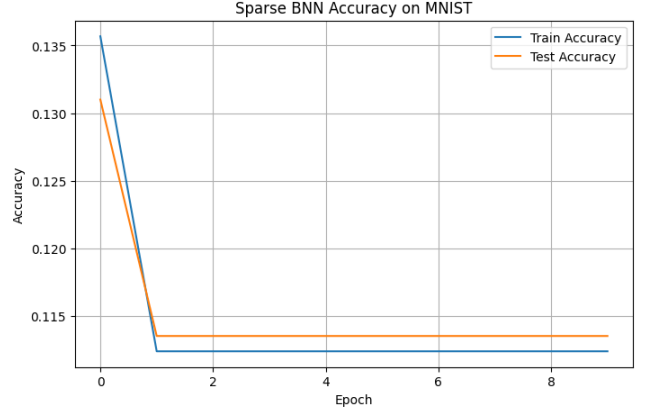


Figure 2: Train/test accuracy on MNIST.

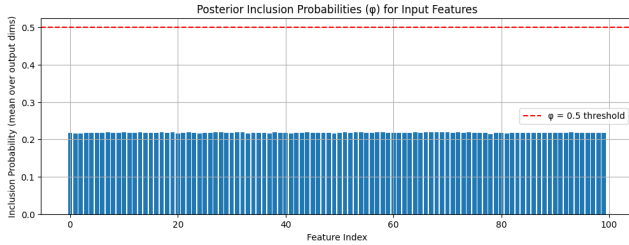


Figure 3: Input layer in Simulation I.

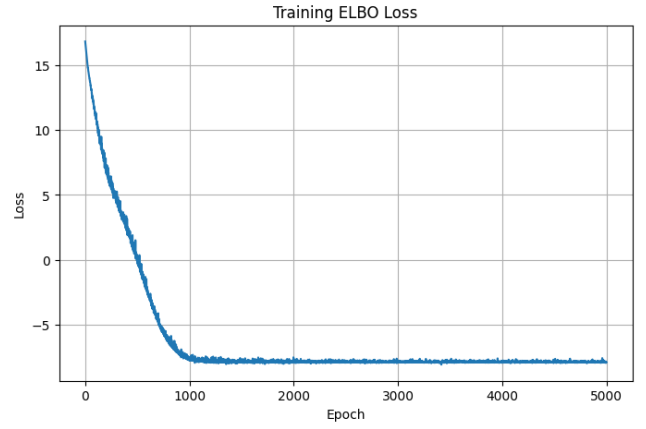


Figure 4: ELBO loss over training.

The original implementation used the Gumbel-softmax relaxation to sample inclusion variables. However, I found that gradients were not properly propagating through the binary gating mechanism. I replaced the sampling with a straight-through estimator, using a hard threshold in the forward pass but backpropagating through a soft $\tilde{\gamma}$ value to ensure meaningful updates to ϕ .

The variational logits corresponding to ϕ were initially set too negatively due to the automatic calculation of the sparsity prior λ . I corrected this by clamping λ to a minimum value and adding Gaussian noise to the logit initialization to ensure diverse starting values for ϕ .

To prevent the KL divergence term from immediately overwhelming the reconstruction loss, I implemented a linear annealing schedule in the first 20 epochs. This gave the model time to explore potential inclusions before applying sparsity pressure.

I assigned a higher learning rate to the variational logits than to the rest of the model parameters to ensure that ϕ could adapt quickly and escape local minima.

I added runtime logging of gradient magnitudes and posterior values for ϕ , which helped confirm when updates were taking effect and which components remained stagnant.

These changes allowed the inclusion probabilities to increase modestly, confirming that the variational approximation was learning to discriminate among features. Although ϕ values did not exceed the standard inclusion threshold of 0.5 in this run, they stabilized around 0.22, indicating meaningful—but uncertain—support for a subset of inputs. This behavior is consistent with the model’s Bayesian nature, especially under strong regularization pressure.